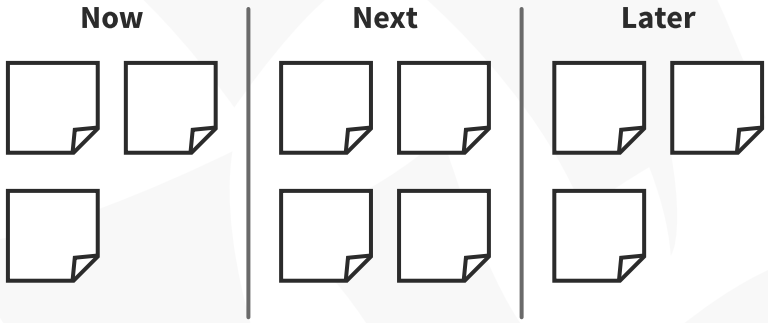

Product Roadmap

A **Product Roadmap** is a tool to communicate what steps you will take to meet the product vision and business objectives.

People often equate product roadmaps with Gantt charts — a granular breakdown of tasks arranged on a timeline. While Gantt charts can be used to visualize the roadmap, they are not the ideal format for agile teams. The reason is that it is extremely hard to accurately estimate the time it takes to deliver a feature. If teams constantly work to tight deadlines, they will end up cutting corners and deploying low-quality code that will ultimately harm the product in the future. Adding a buffer to estimates to stretch out the timelines seems reasonable, but in practice, teams end up filling up any additional time they get with more work.

The main purpose of the product roadmap should be to communicate what the team will be working on to meet the product vision and business objectives. These needn't be bound to specific timelines, and shouldn't be broken down into tasks. Instead of specific tasks, add **problems** to the roadmap, and **prioritize** what you want to solve *now*, what comes *next*, and what problems you will park for *later*.

Use the product roadmap as a **prototype for product strategy**. You can revisit the roadmap from time to time and iterate based on new insights and customer feedback. The idea is to solve the most important problems first and not waste resources on building the wrong thing, because you are stuck with a roadmap that was drawn 6 months ago. By focusing on broader categories like Now/Next/Later, we can help teammates see far enough into the future to plan but not so far that we lose the ability to iterate or change our priorities as we discover new information.

The Now/Next/Later roadmap was developed by Janna Bastow (**website**), CEO and Co-Founder of ProdPad and the co-founder of Mind the Product.

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Experimenting on a Lean Roadmap

Now	Next	Later
Objective Current **development** work in progress. • Experiment 01 ✓ • Experiment 02 ✗ • Experiment 03 ↻	**Objective** Top confidence for next work opening.	**Objective** Likely 6+ months away, but checking that it aligns with vision.
	Objective	
Objective Current **prototyping** work in progress. • Experiment 01 ✓ • Experiment 02 ↻ • Experiment 03 ↻ • Experiment 04 ↻	**Objective**	**Objective**
	Objective	**Objective**

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Product Roadmap Template

Now	Next	Later

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